journalism. As a result, democracy gets compromised.' How prescient he was. Some in the national media continued to take stabs in the dark, just vilifying the Yatra. I was quite angry at how unfair and untrue it all was.

But we had a job to do, so I couldn't let myself indulge this anger (however legitimate it may have been) for too long. The national media manufactured controversies around Rahul Gandhi's meeting with a local bishop, around our homage to Swami Vivekananda's statue in Kanyakumari and the implanted Savarkar cut-outs in between our publicity campaign. But no matter what they did, we tackled their hostility with the truth. We kept our cool and put out things factually. And no matter what was tried, they failed to disrupt the patriotic tenor that was only growing by the day. Like the ebbing of the tides, the Yatra continued to march, tackling the hurdles and small victories that inevitably came our way.

In the Maharashtra stretch of the Yatra, which I was assigned to coordinate, I was a bit alone. Due to a strange quirk of fate, neither the media in-charge, nor the fellow media coordinator assigned along with me were going to be there on duty, since they were both preoccupied with the assembly elections in Himachal Pradesh and New Delhi. As I was nervously fretting about whether I would be able to handle the massive responsibility, someone suggested I avoid Maharashtra altogether. His reasoning was that the terrain was harsh and had no good hotels (which sometimes became necessary for the press conferences and also for our stay, especially when we had to work until late at night). I was determined to not heed that advice, because I was firmly committed to the cause that my leader (and I) had taken up. At the risk of looking silly (which I secretly apprehended) or naively idealistic (a common feedback I keep getting), I decided to stay true to the path I had committed myself to. In fact, Rahul Gandhi's clarion call of '*Daro Mat* (Don't Be Afraid)', which was meant for something else, became a source of strength for me. Plus, I kept telling myself that if Rahul, with an injured knee, was walking 25 kilometres per day, braving all kinds of trials, why couldn't I? And so I soldiered on!

Nanded (which is a sacred place for Sikhs, given it is Guru Gobind Singh's resting place) embraced me warmly as the Yatra commenced there